

SCA Examination Day Guide

A comprehensive guide to sitting your examination
on the Osler Online platform.

Introduction

This guide provides a comprehensive overview of your SCA examination day. It will cover all the key aspects of the examination from logging in, candidate registration with your invigilator, navigating each station from reading time to consultation, breaks and logging off. You will be able to familiarise yourself with key platform functionality and learn about how to seek support if you need to do so throughout the examination.

After reading this guide you will be left with a clear understanding of exactly what to expect from your SCA, so you can go into your examination day feeling well prepared.

It is important to note that this guide has been developed in conjunction with the Trainee Surgery Guide, which provides a detailed look at the steps you need to take in order to prepare yourself in the weeks leading up to your examination day.

Please read and complete the steps laid out in the Trainee Surgery Guide ahead of reading this document. You can find the Trainee Surgery Guide on our SCA webpage.

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Examination day schedule

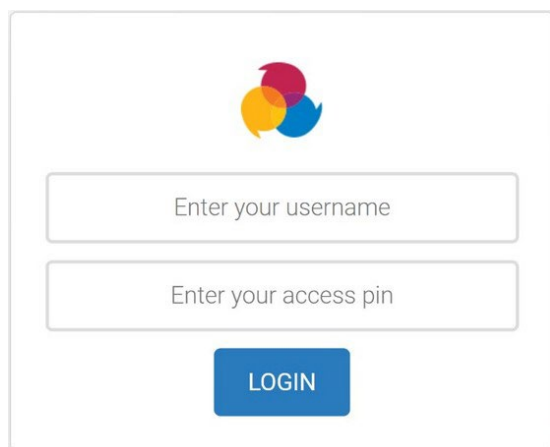
There will be two SCA examinations scheduled per day, and you will be allocated to either the AM or PM examination. The scheduled running time for the AM examination session is 08.45 to 13.25 and for the PM session it is 13.20 to 18.05. The scheduled running time will also apply to those trainees with a reasonable adjustment of 25% extra reading time. Trainees with other reasonable adjustments including extra consultation time or extra breaks should plan for their examination session to run from 08.45 to 15.00.

Your examination session will run as follows:

AM Schedule	PM Schedule	Examination activities
08:45	13:20	Candidate registration (45 mins). Login to Osler. The invigilator will conduct the ID and environment check. Please be patient, it may take some time for the invigilator to appear.
09:30	14:10	Examination starts.
09:30 - 11:00	14:10 - 15:40	Rounds 1-6 (1hr 30mins). 15 mins per station (3 mins reading time, followed by a 12 min video or telephone consultation with the role player).
11:00 - 11:10	15:40 - 15:50	Comfort break (10 mins). Please note that to leave the room you must message the invigilator. Please also message your invigilator once you have returned.
11:10 - 12:40	15:50 - 17:20	Rounds 7-12 (1hr 30mins). 15 mins per station (3 mins reading time, followed by a 12 min video or telephone consultation with role player).
12:40 - 13:25	17:20 - 18:05	Rounds end, wrapping-up and rerun time begins (45 mins). Please note you <u>may not log</u> out or leave your examination room at any point during the wrapping up and rerun period.
13:25	18:05	Examination officially ends. You may log out once given permission by the invigilator.

Logging on to the platform

Two weeks prior to your examination you will receive an email from the examinations team containing a URL link to the platform and your own unique username and password. By clicking on the URL, you will be taken directly to our login portal to enter the details provided. If you would like to take a look around the platform ahead of examination day, you can log in to the platform as soon as you receive the email with the URL and your log in details.

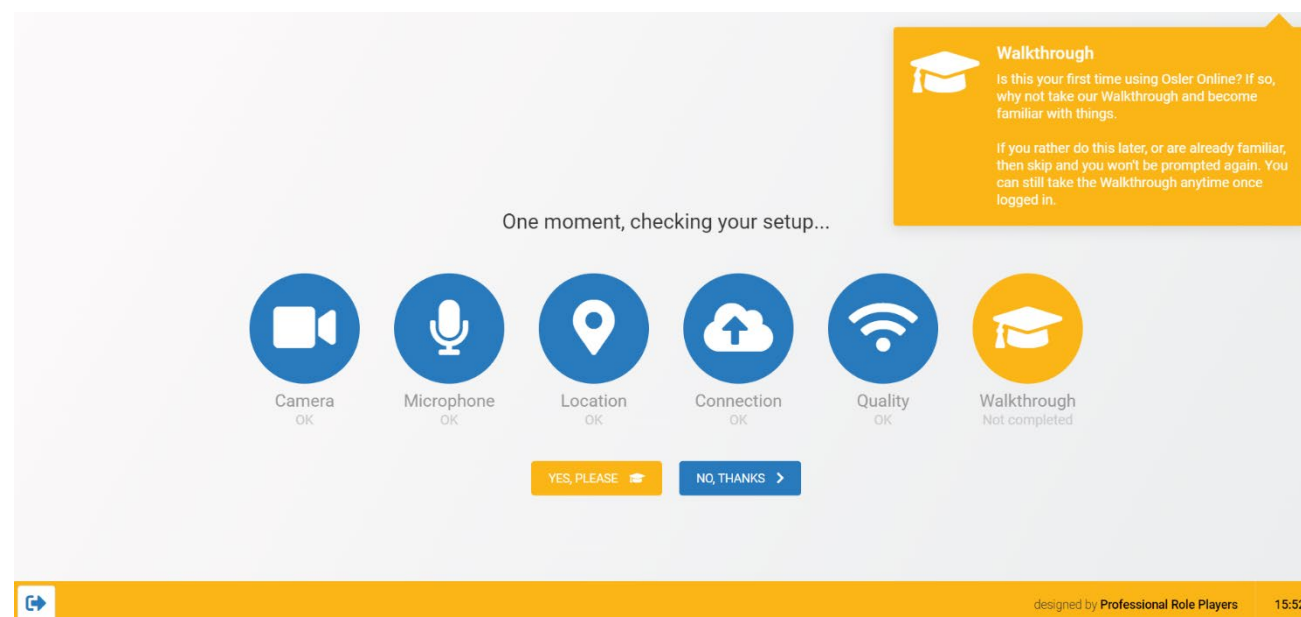


The login portal interface is a light gray rectangular box. At the top center is a logo consisting of three overlapping circles in red, yellow, and blue. Below the logo are two white rectangular input fields with thin gray borders. The first field contains the placeholder text "Enter your username". The second field contains the placeholder text "Enter your access pin". Below these fields is a solid blue rectangular button with the word "LOGIN" in white, uppercase letters.

Automatic device check

After you have successfully logged in, the platform will take you through a device check. It will automatically test your microphone, video and internet connection.

If you experience any issues during this check and are unable to connect to the platform, please contact the IT Support helpline on 020 3188 7680. On the day of the examination, please have your phone on hand, as the IT team will try to call you to offer support if you do not appear on the examination platform.



Video feed

From there you will proceed to a screen that will capture your video feed and audio volume accurately.

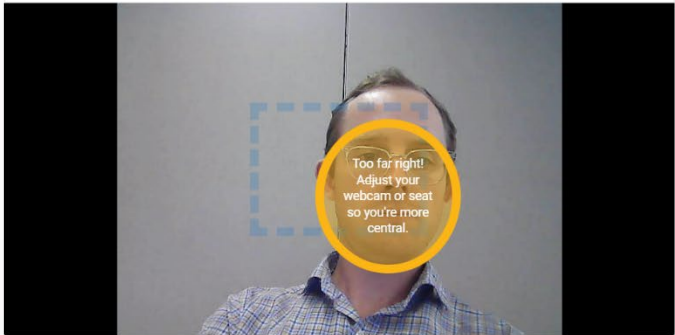
Follow the onscreen instructions to position your face correctly in the frame of your video feed. A blue oval will appear around your face when you are correctly positioned. If it shows a yellow oval, you are not correctly aligned and will need to adjust your position until the oval turns blue, and you are correctly positioned in the frame.

It is important that you are positioned correctly on camera. Firstly, so your role player has a clear view of you throughout the consultation and secondly, so that your examiner can see you properly, to mark the station accurately.

**Position check**

Use this tool to make sure you're well positioned and clearly seen. Try to position your face inside the dashed box.

The tool will let you know if it thinks your face can't easily be seen, if you're too close or too far away, or if you're too far over to one side.



PROCEED

**Volume check**

Use this tool to check your microphone volume by recording your voice and listening back.

If too quiet or too loud you may consider adjusting the distance you are from the microphone or changing your device settings.

Select microphone

Communications - Microphone (Logitech USB Headset)

☒

Microphone Array (Realtek(R) Audio)

☐

Microphone (Logitech USB Headset)

☐


Start recording


End recording


Play recording

designed by Professional Role Players15:59

Audio test

Now it's time to test your audio and microphone. Click on the blue **start recording** icon and speak clearly. For example, you could say 'testing, testing, 1,2,3'.



When you have finished speaking, press the **end recording** icon.



Then press the **play recording** icon to hear what your audio sounds like when it plays back.



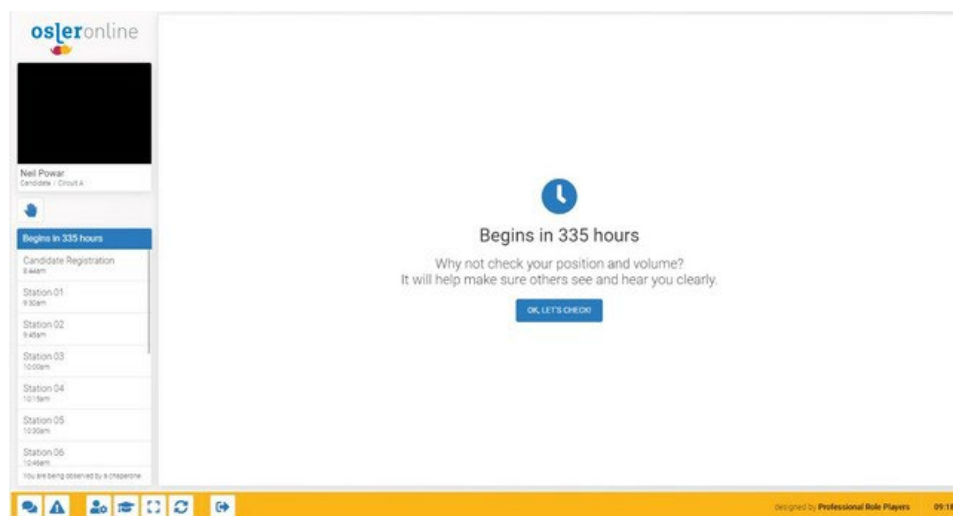
Your audio will play back through your speakers to confirm your microphone is working and for you to check the volume. If you are too loud or too quiet, you can adjust your distance from your microphone or adjust your device volume.

When your video feed and audio check is complete you can click **proceed** at the bottom of the screen and you will be taken through to the waiting room for candidate registration.

Waiting room

Two weeks before the examination

You can see the image below is of an examination waiting room where the timer on the screen indicates that the examination will begin in 335 hours.



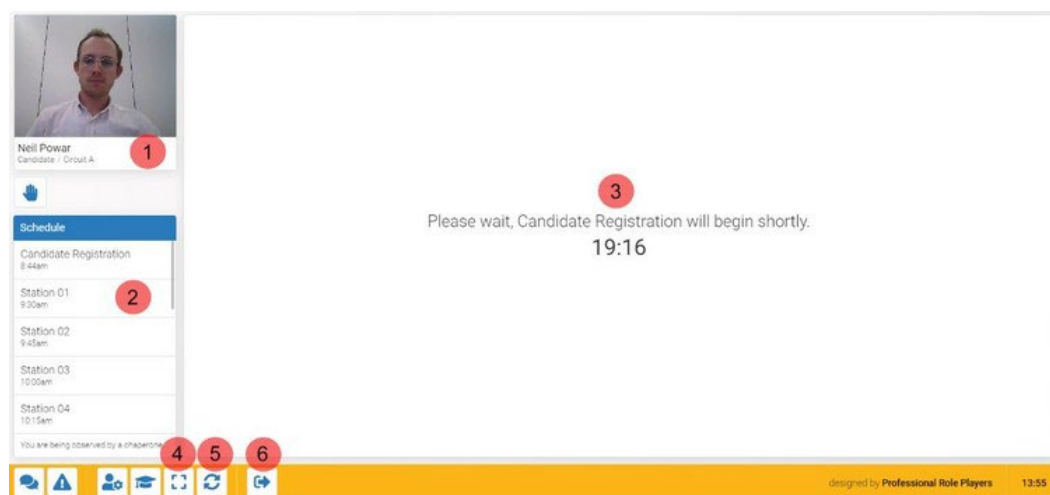
Schedule - Take this time to familiarise yourself with the schedule on the left-hand side of your screen. Under each station, including your break, you will see a time indicated. This will enable you to keep track of how your examination will run from start to finish. The platform will automatically transition you between stations and your break. Please note the schedule will only be visible on the platform before your registration begins, in between stations and during the break.

Walkthrough – you can press the  icon on the yellow bar to complete the platform walkthrough as many times as you like, ahead of your examination day, to refresh your memory on the platform functionality. You will also be prompted to complete the walkthrough when you log in for the first time.

On the day

On your examination day you will log in to the platform and remain in the examination waiting room until the platform automatically moves you through to your candidate registration. You can see the timer on the screen now shows that your candidate registration will start in under 20 minutes.

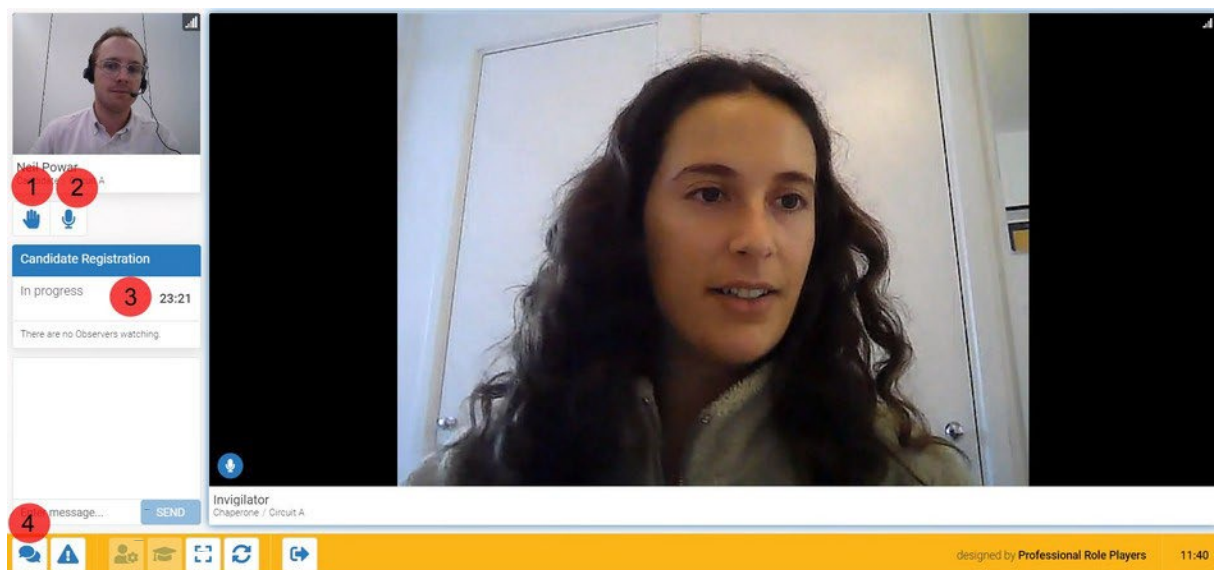
Here is some key functionality to note on this screen while waiting for your candidate registration to begin.



1. Camera view – this window displays your video feed, so you can check your positioning on screen and how you will appear to the invigilator, role player and examiner.
2. Schedule – this is the schedule for your examination. As you can see the schedule is showing that you are currently waiting for your candidate registration to begin.
3. Countdown – the middle of the screen is indicating the time left until your candidate registration.
4. Full screen – this button removes the tabs at the top of your page and expands your screen.
5. Refresh – You can automatically refresh the examination platform if you're encountering any technical issues.
6. Log out – you can log out of Osler Online using this button. Please note, on examination days you should only log out if asked to do so by the examinations team or at the end of the examination when your invigilator gives you permission to do so.

Candidate registration

This is what your screen will look like when your invigilator joins you for your candidate registration. Don't worry if you are not greeted by your invigilator as soon as registration begins, they will acknowledge that they can see you on the platform as soon as possible. Please note, it may take up to 30 minutes for them to join you to perform the ID and environment checks. The screen shot below highlights some key functionality to help you communicate with your invigilator during the registration period and the examination.



1. Hand raise – this button will allow you to notify your invigilator if you need to contact them at any stage throughout the examination. It is a useful tool to use if you need to get their attention, but you are in the middle of a consultation and don't have time to type out a direct message.
2. Mute – This button will mute and unmute your microphone. When there is a line through the microphone icon you are muted. Click it again to remove the line and unmute.
3. Countdown timer - This timer tells you how much longer you have until your candidate registration ends.
4. Direct message - Your invigilator will show you where you can access the direct message function on the platform in case you need to send them a message at any stage throughout the examination.



ID check

When your invigilator joins you, they will first ask you to complete an ID check. Please ensure you have a Government-issued photographic ID (e.g. Passport or UK Driving License) ready to show them. All you will need to do is hold your ID up to your camera, for the invigilator to see and confirm your details. If your ID looks blurry when you hold it up to the camera, as a result of your camera being unable to focus, you will be required to take a selfie to verify your identity. Before your examination begins, or during your break, you will need to hold your ID up to your face and take a selfie. Email this selfie to exams@rcgp.org.uk for verification. Your invigilator will give you full guidance on this process, if you are required to do it.

Environment check

Next will be the environment check where your invigilator will ask you to use your device camera to show them a 360-degree view of your examination space. Please ensure your walls are clear of clinical guidance documents, medical charts and posters prior to starting the environment check, as these items are prohibited. Please note, when you are performing the 360-degree check, in instances where the web cam is bolted on or embedded in your monitor, the invigilator will ask you to perform the environment check using a combination of your web cam and the camera on your mobile phone, so make sure you have your phone on hand, if required.

The invigilator will also observe your workspace. Please ensure it is clear except for these optional items:

A water bottle

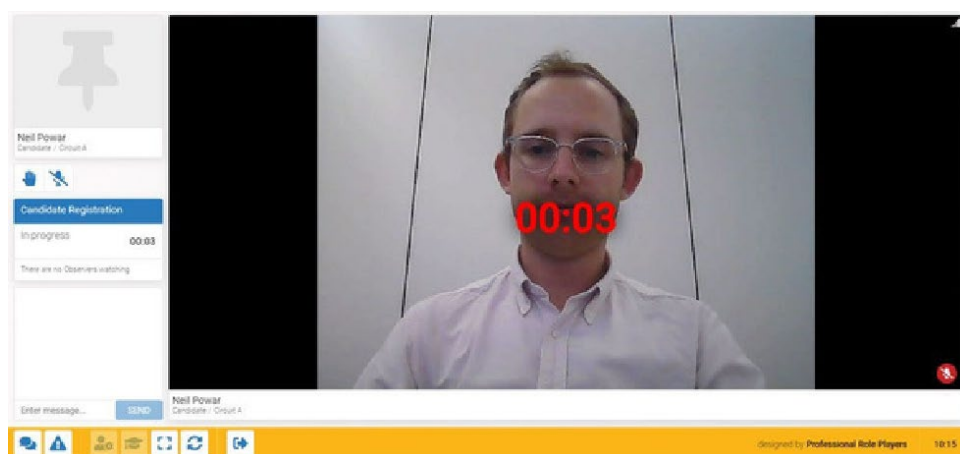
A whiteboard and marker to take manual notes.

If you lose contact with your invigilator at any stage throughout your ID and environment check, please contact IT Support on **020 3188 7680**.

When your invigilator has completed their checks, they will leave you to wait for your examination to begin. Keep an eye on your countdown timer on the left so you know how much longer you need to wait.



When your candidate registration is about to end you will see a red 5 second timer appear prominently on the screen.



Reading time

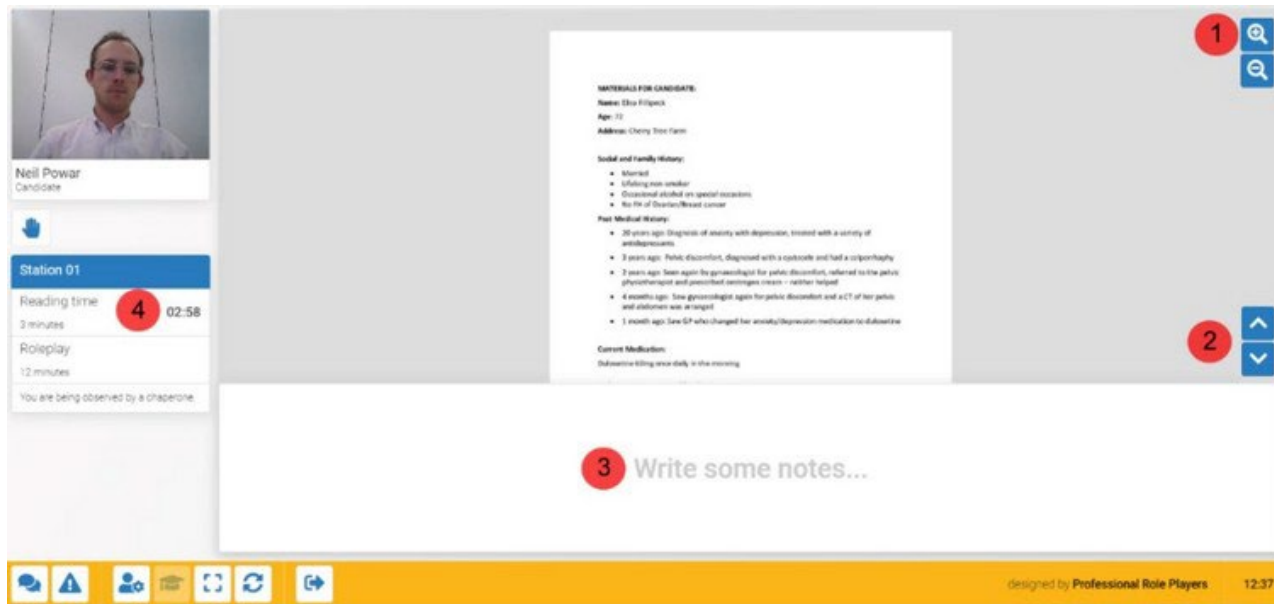
You will have 15 seconds between your candidate registration ending and your first reading time beginning.

The screenshot shows a video call interface. On the left, a small video window shows a man identified as Neil Powar, a candidate for Circuit A. Below the video is a 'Schedule' panel with a list of stations: Station 01 (begins in 6 seconds), Station 02 (9:45am), Station 03 (10:00am), and Station 04 (10:15am). A green checkmark indicates that candidate registration is completed. The main area of the screen displays the text 'Please wait for reading time to begin.' and a timer showing '00:06'. At the bottom, there is a yellow bar with various icons and the text 'designed by Professional Role Players' and '10:16'.

From there the platform will automatically take you through to your first station to begin your reading time. You will have three minutes to read your candidate brief.

Key functionality

This image shows you the key features you can use to read and take notes on your candidate brief.



1. Zoom in and out – you can use the + icon to zoom into the brief document and make it larger and you can use the – icon to zoom out and reduce its size.
2. Scroll - There are arrows down the right-hand side of the screen that will allow you to move through your candidate brief. You can also click and drag your brief up and down using your mouse or track pad.
3. Notes window – This is where you can type in any notes you would like to make about the brief. These notes will be automatically carried through to your consultation. The notes you take are private and cannot be seen by anyone during or after the examination.
4. Countdown timer – This timer indicates the time remaining for your reading time.

You may also see one or more of the following messages on your brief:

- **'This is a telephone case - you will hear the patient but not see them'** - To inform you on whether to expect a video case or a telephone case in your upcoming consultation.
- **'Please scroll down'** - To indicate if there is another page in the brief.
- **'End of notes'** - To indicate that you have come to the end of the brief.

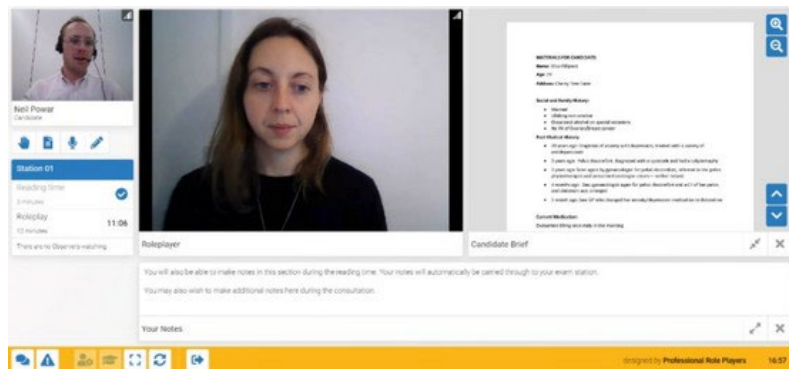
Consultation



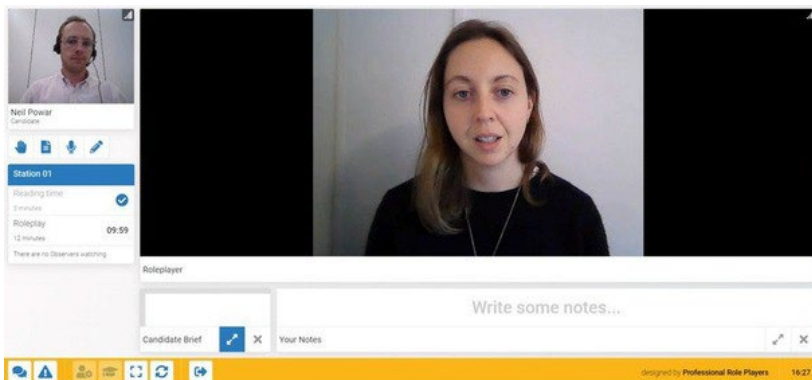
When your three-minute reading time has ended you will be automatically taken through to your first consultation. The role player will appear on screen, and you can begin speaking with them. Please note, it may take up to 30 seconds for the video call with your role player to stabilise. If, after this time, you are still experiencing issues with the video or audio quality, please contact your invigilator.

Both your brief and your notes will automatically be carried over from your reading time.

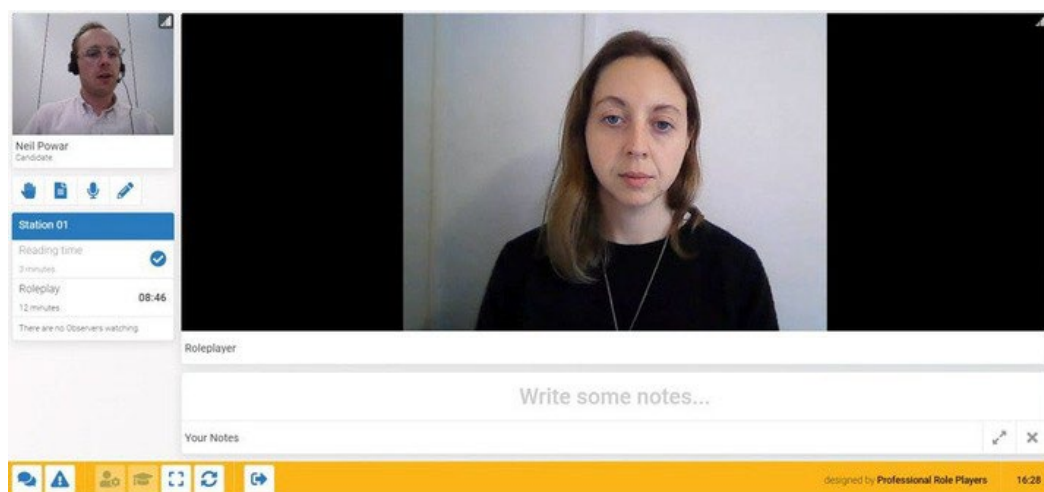
This is how your screen will appear when the consultation first begins. The role player will be on the left, the brief will be on the right and your notes will be across the bottom.



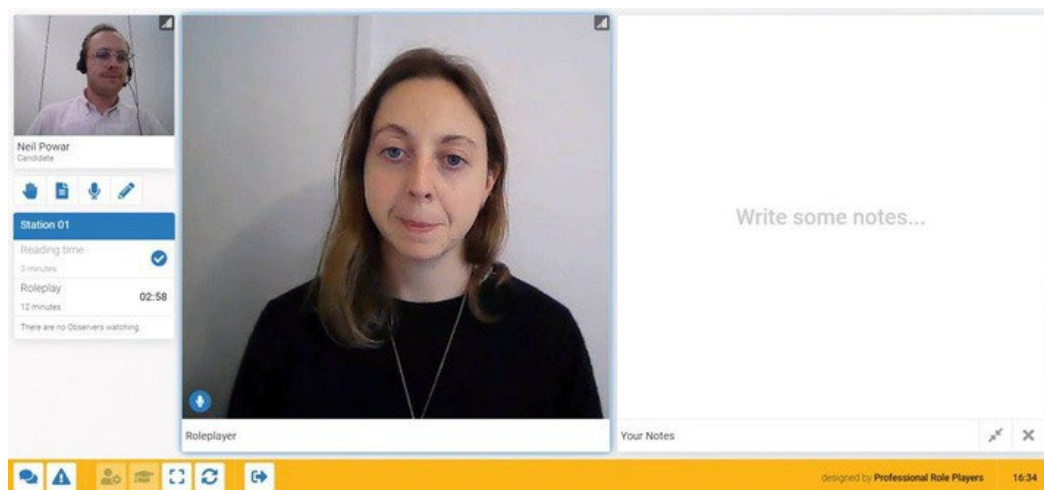
If you don't think you will need to access your brief throughout the consultation, you can press the  button to minimise the brief and place it next to your notes.



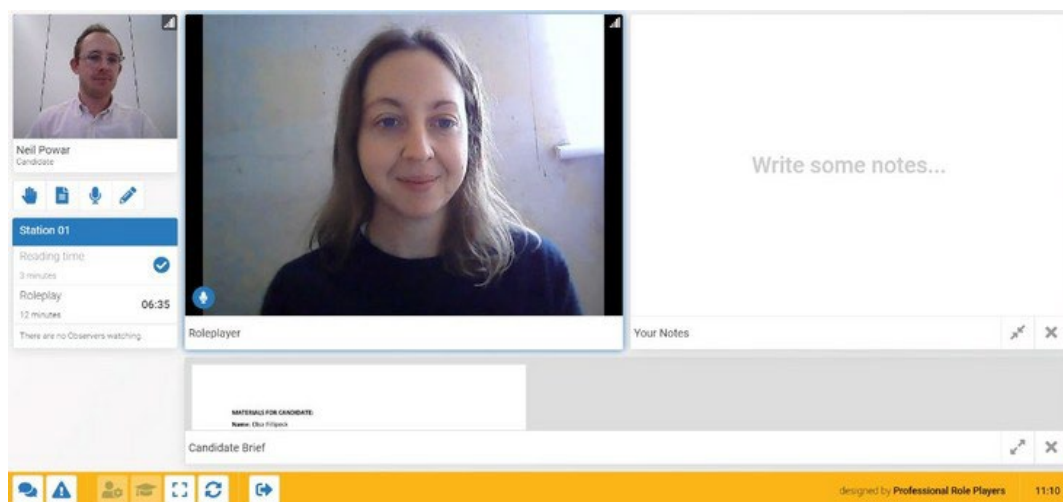
If you would like to close the brief entirely press the **X** button. Now only your notes will appear across the bottom of the screen.



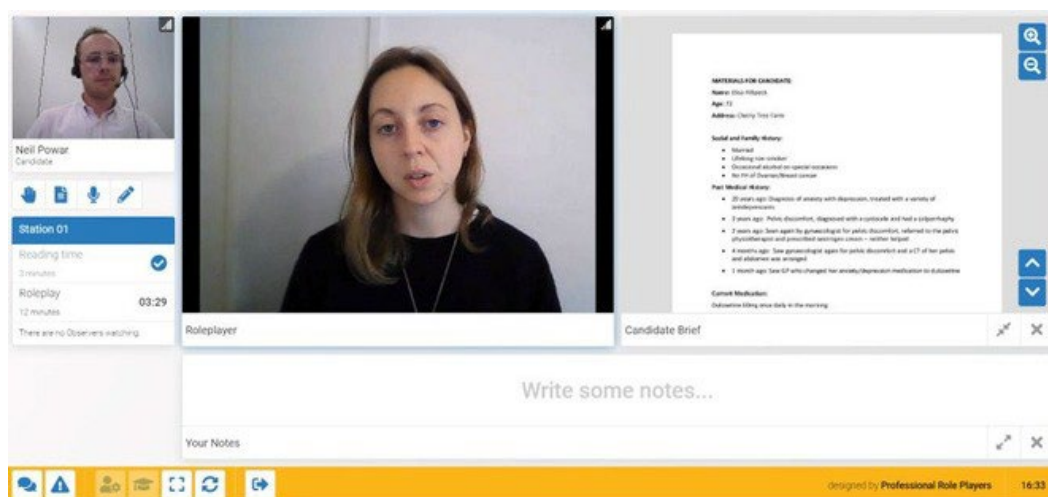
If you would like to expand your notes press the **↗** button to bring them up beside the role player.



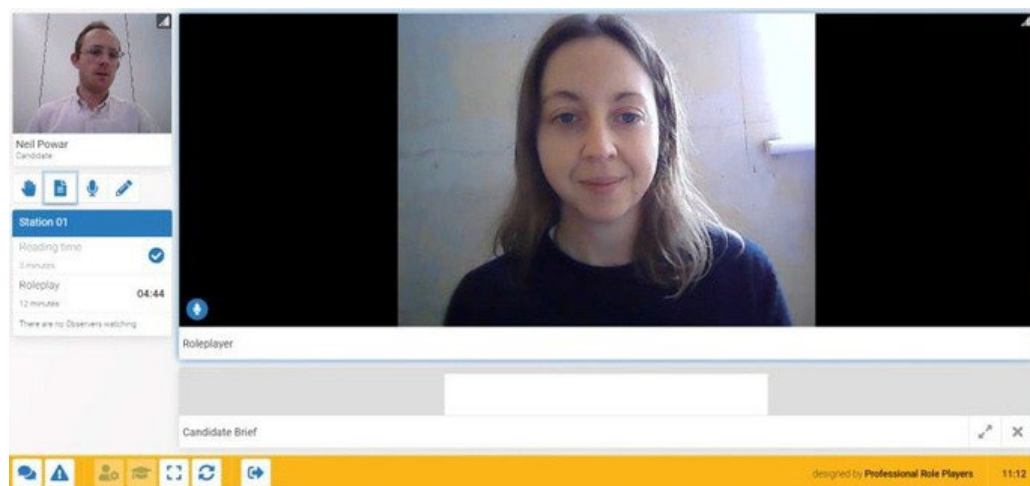
If you would like to bring the brief back up you can press the  icon on the left-hand panel. The brief will appear again at the bottom of the screen.



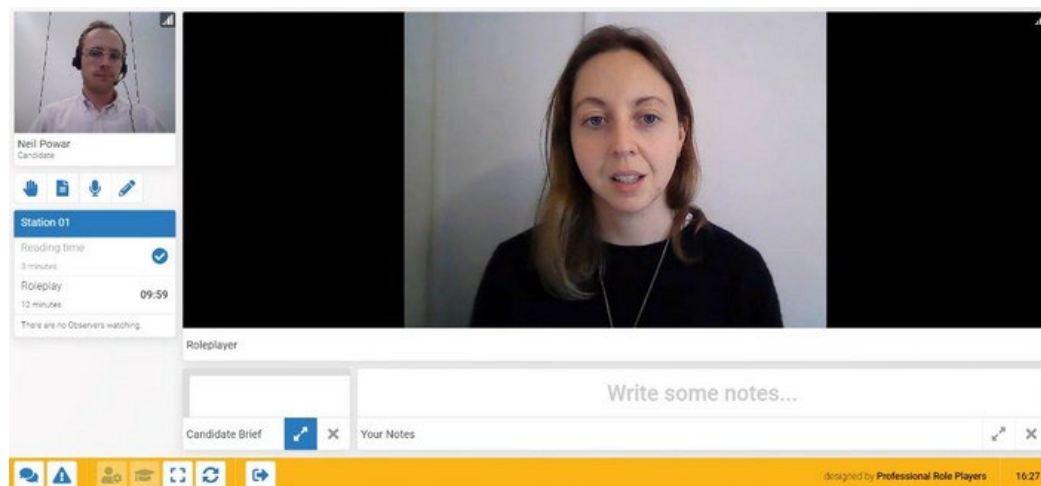
Press the  icon to bring the brief back up to full size beside the role player, now you are back to the original configuration.



If you would like to remove the notes from the screen you can press ✕ button. Now only the candidate brief is visible on screen below the role player.



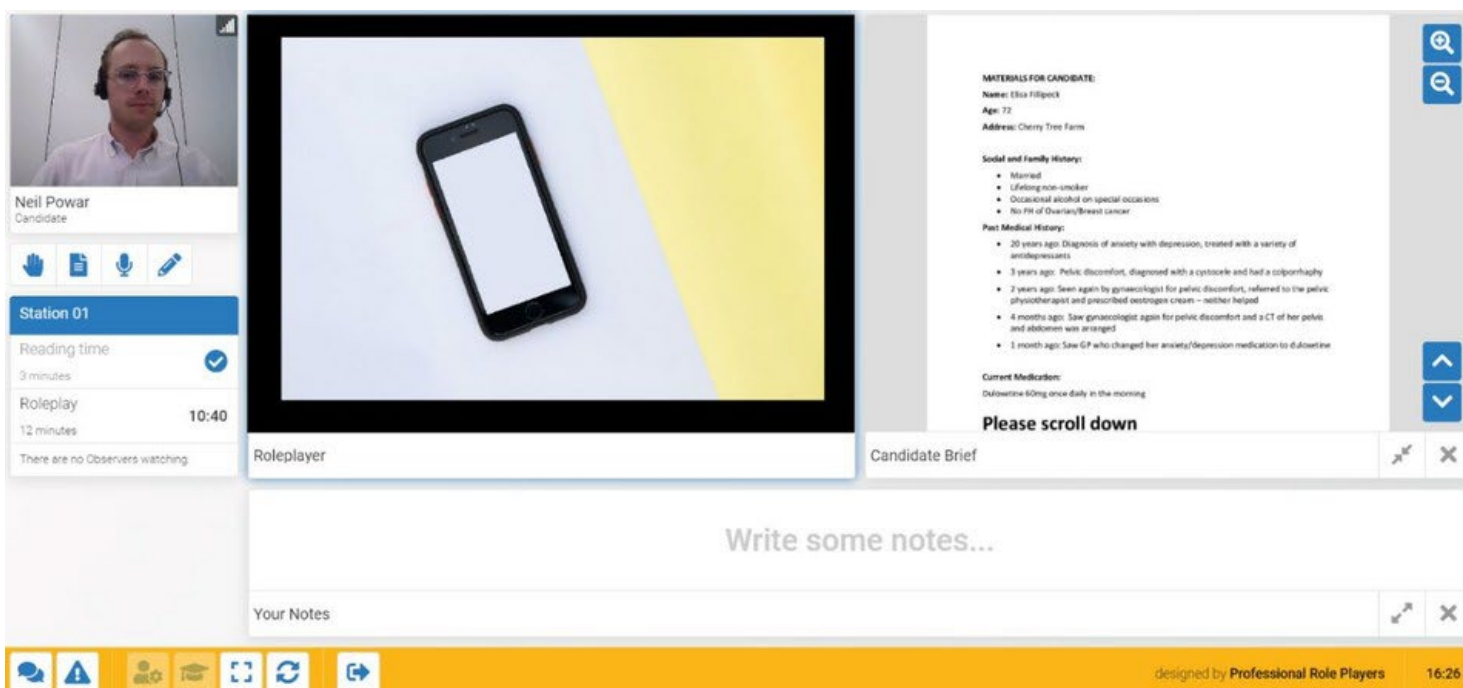
You can press the  icon to bring the notes back up at any time. They will appear at the bottom of the screen once more.



In summary, you can use the expand, minimise and close icons to resize and close your candidate brief and notes, and the pencil or paper icons (below your video feed) to bring them back up at any time.

Telephone consultations

Some of your stations will be video consultations and some will be telephone consultations. If when you read your candidate brief during reading time it indicates that you are having a telephone consultation, then you will not see the role player during the consultation. Instead, the screen will show an image of a telephone and you will simply hear the role player's voice. You will always remain on video, even during telephone consultations so that the invigilator can observe you. However, the role player will not be able to see you during the consultation and the examiner will not see you when marking your consultation.



The screenshot displays the RCGP examination interface for a telephone consultation station. On the left, a video feed shows the candidate, Neil Powar, wearing a headset. Below the video, the candidate's name and role are listed. The central area features a large image of a smartphone on a yellow and white background, labeled 'Roleplayer'. To the right, the 'Candidate Brief' is visible, detailing the patient's history and current medication. The bottom section is a 'Write some notes...' area for taking notes during the consultation. The interface includes various icons for navigation and a status bar at the bottom.

Station 01

Reading time
3 minutes

Roleplay
12 minutes
10:40

There are no Observers watching

MATERIALS FOR CANDIDATE:
Name: Eliza Fillipov
Age: 72
Address: Cherry Tree Farm

Social and Family History:

- Married
- Lifelong non-smoker
- Occasional alcohol on special occasions
- No FH of Ovarian/Breast cancer

Past Medical History:

- 20 years ago: Diagnosis of anxiety with depression, treated with a variety of antidepressants
- 3 years ago: Pelvic discomfort, diagnosed with a cystocele and had a colpocephaly
- 2 years ago: Seen again by gynaecologist for pelvic discomfort, referred to the pelvic physiotherapist and prescribed oestrogen cream – neither helped
- 4 months ago: Saw gynaecologist again for pelvic discomfort and a CT of her pelvis and abdomen was arranged
- 1 month ago: Saw GP who changed her anxiety/depression medication to duloxetine

Current Medication:
Duloxetine 60mg once daily in the morning

Please scroll down

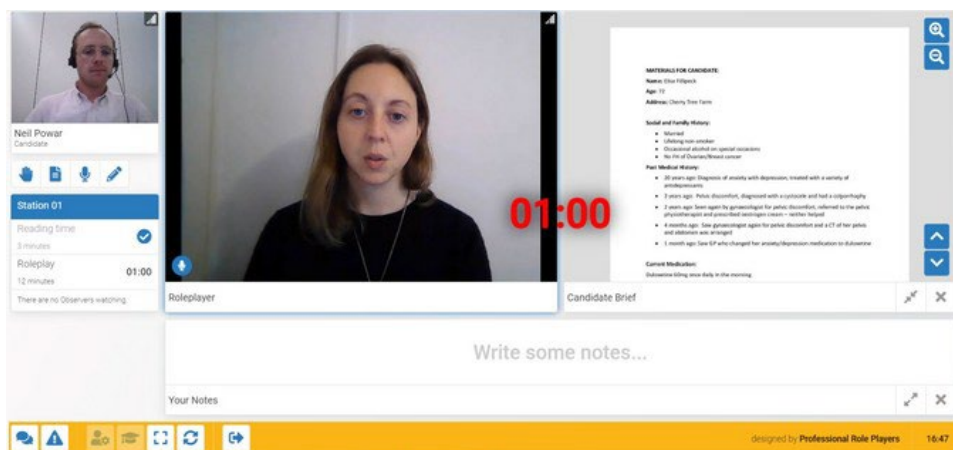
Write some notes...

Your Notes

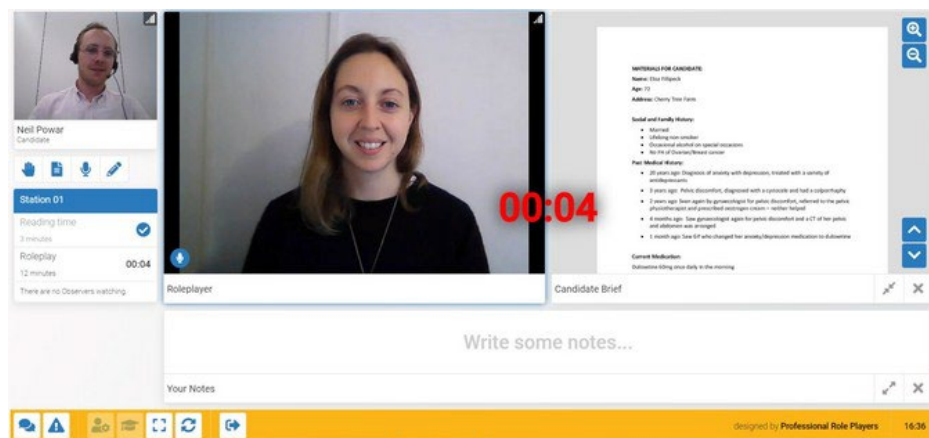
designed by Professional Role Players 16:25

Station ending

When your consultation is drawing to a close a one-minute warning will appear in red in the middle of your screen.



You will then receive a five second countdown to let you know your consultation is about to end.



In between stations

There will be a 15 second gap in between stations where you will be automatically taken back to the examination waiting room.

The time will appear in the middle of your screen to provide you with a countdown until your next station. This is not a break, but rather some time to compose yourself before your next station. You may want to clear your whiteboard (if you're using one) or have a drink of water!

As you move through your stations, the panel to your left will mark those stations that you have completed with a green tick.

The screenshot displays the examination interface. On the left, a candidate profile for Neil Powar is shown. Below it is a 'Schedule' panel with a list of stations. The first four stations (Candidate Registration, Station 01, Station 02, and Station 03) are marked as 'Completed' with green checkmarks. Station 04 is listed as 'Begins in 9 seconds'. A note at the bottom of the schedule panel states 'You are being observed by a chaperone.' The main area of the screen is a large whiteboard with the text 'Please wait for reading time to begin.' and a central countdown timer showing '00:09'. At the bottom, there is a yellow bar containing several icons (chat, alert, settings, help, etc.) and the text 'designed by Professional Role Players' and '13:14'.

Schedule	
Candidate Registration	Completed
Station 01	Completed
Station 02	Completed
Station 03	Completed
Station 04	Begins in 9 seconds

Please wait for reading time to begin.

00:09

You are being observed by a chaperone.

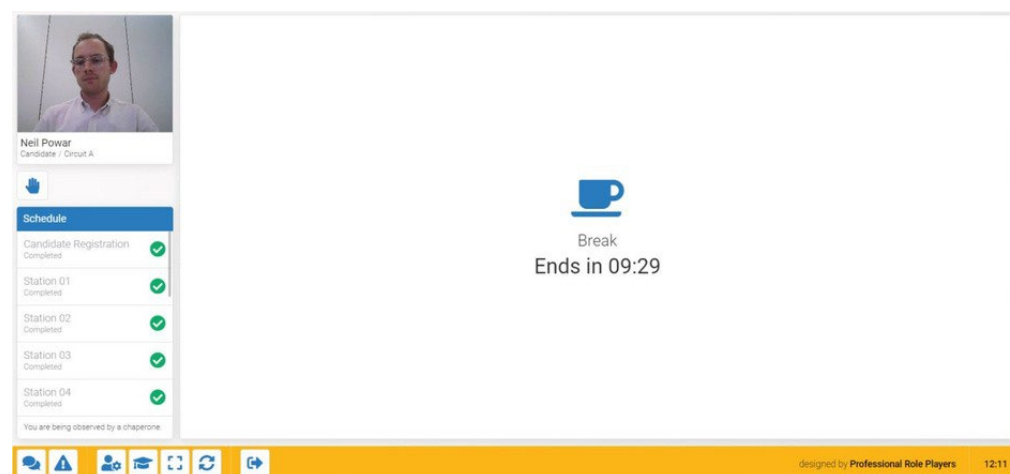
designed by Professional Role Players 13:14

Breaks

When your first six consultations have been completed, you will then enter a 10-minute break period. The examination will pause, and a blue coffee cup icon will appear on your screen along with a countdown that shows how long you have left until your examination begins again.

During the break you are welcome to leave your examination room. However, if you choose to leave the room, you must inform your invigilator through the direct messages function. This is required so that there is a log of the time at which you left the room. You do not need to wait for your invigilator to reply to your message. When you return to the room, send a message to your invigilator to confirm you have returned. You are not permitted to use a phone during the break, as examination conditions will still apply. It is your responsibility to return before your examination recommences.

If you experience any issues during rounds 1-6 of your examination, it is important to flag these to the invigilator during the break time. If the issues are technical, the invigilator can arrange for IT Support to contact you, to resolve them. If you feel the issues impacted your performance in any of the stations, please notify your invigilator and they will arrange for the recording of the consultations to be reviewed by a lead examiner, to determine whether a rerun is required. We cannot guarantee that we can review your rerun query if you do not alert us during this period.

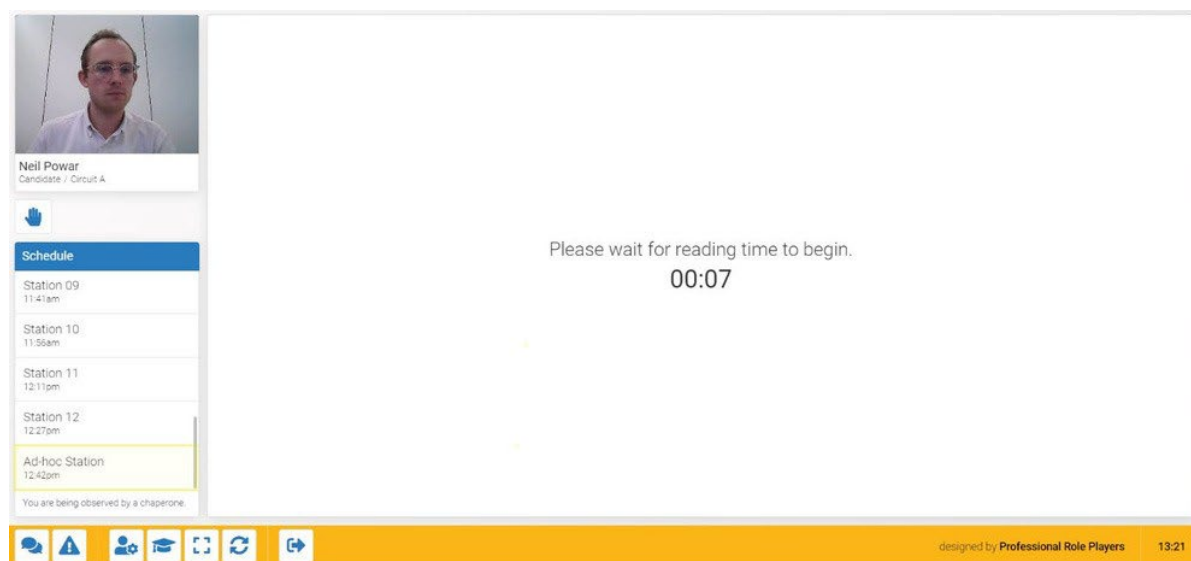


Reruns

45 minutes are reserved for trainees who need to rerun one or more of their stations. If you are required to do a rerun, your invigilator will inform you of this, in person, during the break, or, at the end of your twelfth station. The rerun station will appear as an **Ad-hoc Station** at the bottom of your examination schedule.

Reasons for needing to complete a rerun may include, brief but repetitive drops in signal for the trainee or role player or severe interruption from external noise which prevents the station being successfully completed.

At the end of your twelfth consultation, it is important to immediately flag any issues that you feel impacted your performance in rounds 7-12. There will be a 5-minute break between the scheduled stations endings and any reruns beginning for you to discuss these issues with the invigilator. If required, the invigilator will arrange for the recording of your consultation to be reviewed by a lead examiner, to determine whether a rerun is required. We cannot guarantee that we can review your rerun query if you do not alert us immediately after your twelfth consultation.



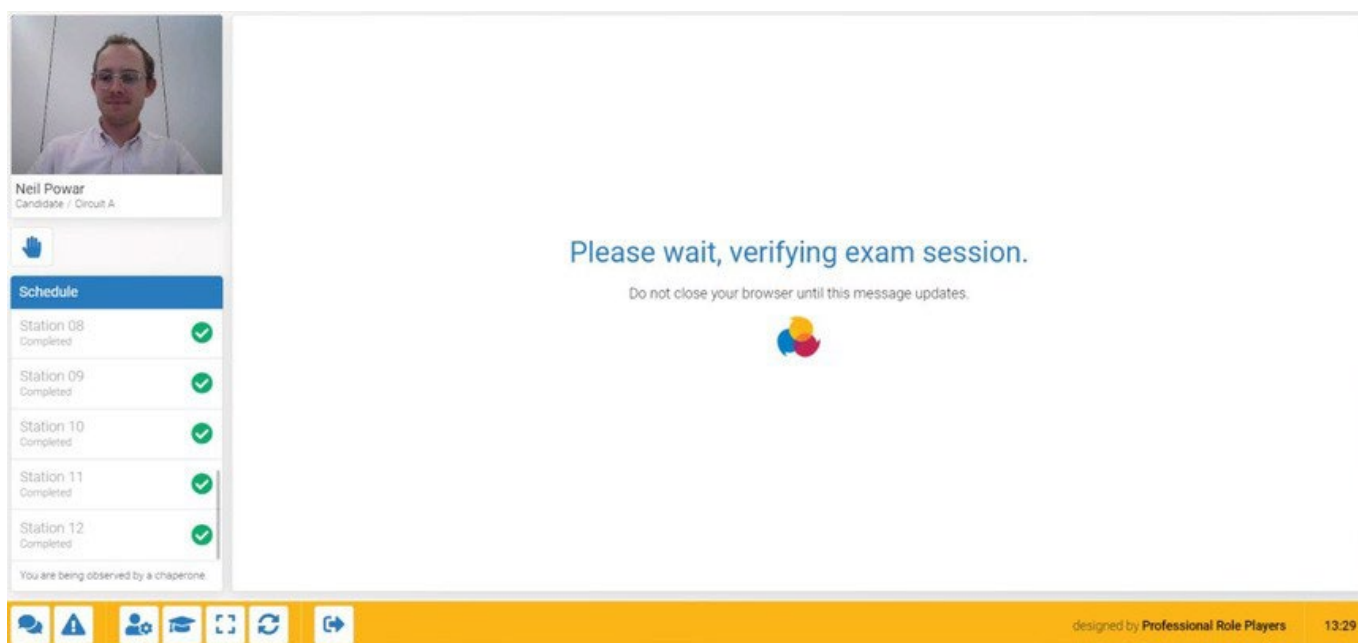
The screenshot displays the examination interface for a candidate named Neil Powar. On the left, a sidebar shows the examination schedule:

- Station 09: 11:41am
- Station 10: 11:56am
- Station 11: 12:11pm
- Station 12: 12:27pm
- Ad-hoc Station: 12:42pm** (highlighted in yellow)

Below the schedule, it states: "You are being observed by a chaperone." The main area of the screen shows a large white space with the text "Please wait for reading time to begin." and a timer displaying "00:07". At the bottom, there is a yellow bar with various icons (chat, alert, settings, etc.) and the text "designed by Professional Role Players" and "13:21".

Logging out

When all your stations are complete you will be taken back to this screen. Please relax whilst your examination is being processed. However, please note that you are still under examination conditions. The examination processing period will be 45 minutes long, however, in some circumstances you may be permitted to leave sooner.



Neil Powar
Candidate / Circuit A

Schedule

Station 08	Completed	✓
Station 09	Completed	✓
Station 10	Completed	✓
Station 11	Completed	✓
Station 12	Completed	✓

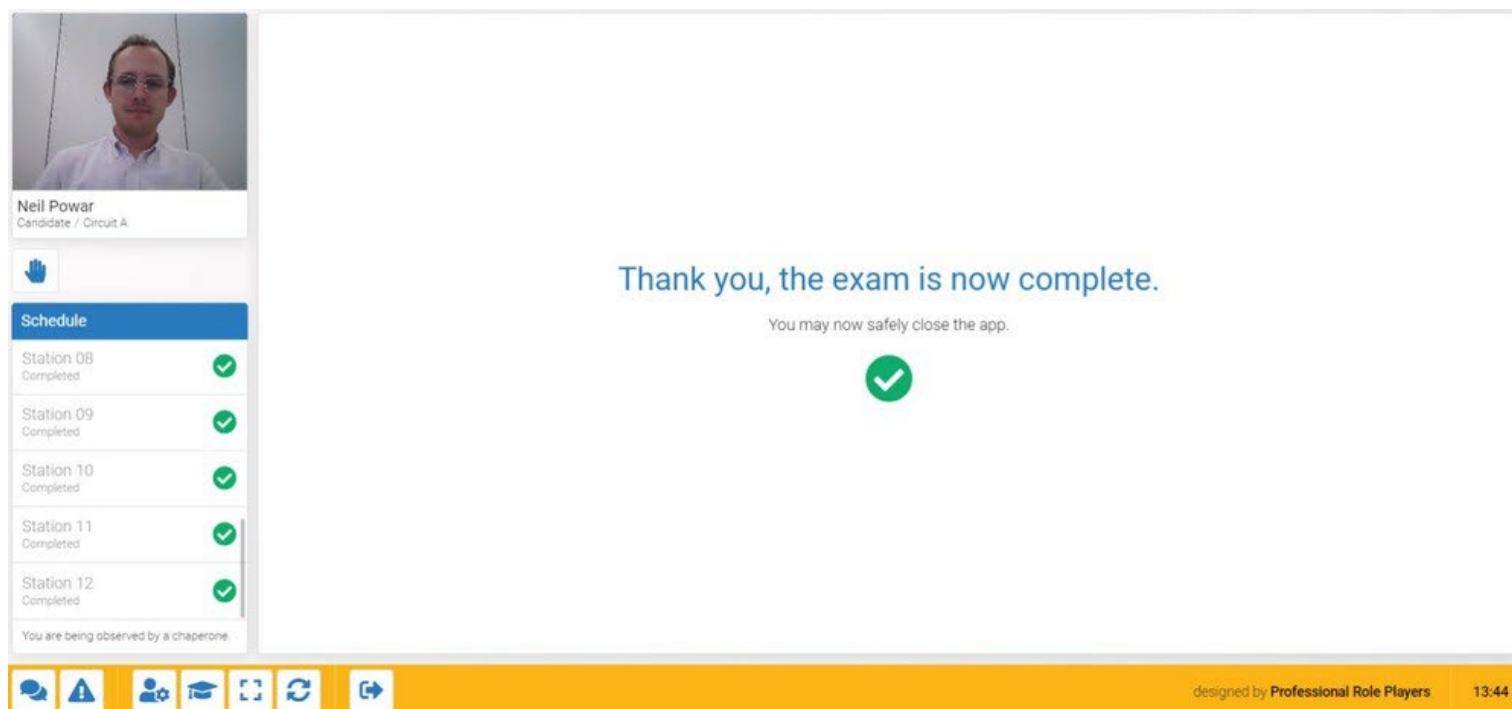
You are being observed by a chaperone

Please wait, verifying exam session.

Do not close your browser until this message updates.

designed by Professional Role Players 13:29

Once your examination has been processed, you will see that the screen changes to the message below. At this point, or shortly thereafter, your invigilator will visit you personally to conclude your examination. If you have been using a whiteboard to take notes, they will ask you to remove the notes and show them, so they can verify that the board has been wiped clear. They will then confirm that your examination is complete, and you are free to log out of the platform.



The screenshot shows a video call interface. On the left, a small video window shows a man with glasses and a white shirt. Below the video, the name 'Neil Powar' and 'Candidate / Circuit A' are displayed. A blue hand icon is visible. Below that is a 'Schedule' section with a list of stations, each marked as 'Completed' with a green checkmark:

Schedule	
Station 08	Completed
Station 09	Completed
Station 10	Completed
Station 11	Completed
Station 12	Completed

Below the schedule, it says 'You are being observed by a chaperone.' The main area of the screen displays the message 'Thank you, the exam is now complete.' in blue text, followed by 'You may now safely close the app.' and a large green checkmark icon. At the bottom, there is a yellow bar with several icons (chat, warning, settings, graduation cap, camera, refresh, and share) and the text 'designed by Professional Role Players' and '13:44'.

FAQS

What happens if we lose internet connection?

If you lose internet connection, you will automatically log out of the platform. Follow the link in the email again and log back in. You will automatically return to your station. If this causes a significant interference to your examination, a re-run of the station can be performed.

What if I freeze mid-examination?

If you experience any issues with your video feed, click the 'refresh' icon at the bottom of your screen. If this does not solve your problem, please log off and back in again.

What if I have a technical problem during the examination?

In the first instance please use the hand raise and direct message features to notify your invigilator. If you cannot connect to the platform, please phone the SCA IT helpline on 020 3188 7680.

I have a question about the SCA examination platform, what do I do?

If you have any questions about the SCA examination platform, you can get in touch at exams@rcgp.org.uk.

Technical issues and troubleshooting

In the event of unexpected technical issues logging in to the platform or throughout the examination, we strongly suggest you bring the following, if they are available to you:

- Laptop and charger (it is fine to use a personal or GP practice laptop for the examination, alternatively we recommend having an additional device available).
- Mobile phone and charger – please check your phone if you are having issues, as we will call you to provide IT support.
- Wired headphones. If you are experiencing any sound issues, these can often be resolved by switching from the inbuilt speaker and microphone to wired headphones. Bluetooth headsets are not permitted.

Sometimes unexpected connection issues can be resolved by swapping to an alternate Wi-Fi network, which may be less restricted or have a better connection strength. Whilst not compulsory, we would appreciate you speaking to your practice manager to attain any Wi-Fi network passwords our IT Support may require on examination day. Not every practice will have an alternate Wi-Fi network or a network that requires a password.

Please note: If you experience any technical issues during the examination, please contact your invigilator. If you cannot reach your invigilator please contact IT support on **020 3188 7680**.

Troubleshooting cont.

Below are some quick checks you can perform yourself if you are having issues while on Osler Online. If these checks fail, please call your invigilator.

Logging in issues

- Make sure you have copy and pasted the URL correctly.
- When typing in your username, make sure you don't have caps lock on.
- When typing in username or login pin make sure there are no spaces.

Video issues

- Make sure all permissions have been enabled on your browser.
- Close all other video-streaming software including Teams/Zoom.
- Make sure you are sitting in a well-lit room.
- If you still experience video feed issues press the refresh button in the bottom yellow panel of the screen. It will take 15 seconds to reconnect you to the examination platform and reboot your video feed.

Audio issues

- If you hear echoing, do not move closer to your screen, it will make the echo worse.
- Try turning the volume down on your device as it may be carrying through your microphone.
- If you still experience audio feed issues press the refresh button in the bottom yellow panel of the screen. It will take 15 seconds to reconnect you to the examination platform and reboot your audio.
- Try using an external wired headphone and microphone.

Please note, it may take up to 30 seconds for the video call with your role player to stabilise. If, after this time, you are still experiencing issues with the video or audio quality, please contact your invigilator.



Remember

Use an updated version of Google Chrome or Microsoft Edge.

Only use a PC, Laptop or Mac (no phones or tablets).

Use the same device and location you used for the device check.

For further details, please visit the [SCA webpage](#).